The Prime Minister's address to the Nation from the ramparts of the Red Fort is an event seen and heard by millions of people worldwide. Right from the day in 1947 when the tricolour was hoisted for the first time in independent India, the GOC Delhi area has been part of the ceremony. That flag has been carefully preserved and is on display in the Army Battle Honours Mess in Delhi. On the Prime Minister's arrival at the Red Fort, he is accorded a ceremonial Guard of Honour and then escorted to the ramparts by the GOC, where the Service Chiefs are waiting. The Prime Minister then moves up to the embrasure on the rampart to hoist the national flag. During the address to the nation, it was customary for the GOC to stand a few paces to the rear. During the final rehearsal for the 15 August event, the SPG, which looks after the PM's security, conveyed that the GOC could stand a little further to the rear. The Defence Secretary, Shri Sanjay Mitra, and the COS, Maj Gen Rajesh Sahai, were both present at this rehearsal-cum-security review meeting. While the Defsec had no issues with this arrangement, the COS quite rightly said that he would have to convey this request to the Army HQ as it was beyond his mandate to approve such a change. The COS returned to the HQ after the rehearsal and this issue of where the GOC is to stand dominated the discussion in South Block. My view was that we don't take orders from the SPG but from the Chief, and we would abide by his decision. The matter continued to simmer until Gen Rawat rang me up on the 14th evening. 'Why do you want to stand like an ADC throughout the address?' he said. 'Just sit down with the rest of us and then go back to escort the PM after the event is over.' And that is just what I did.

Some people, however, who were obviously not in the know, tried to create a controversy out of it. There were dozens of messages on social media that went viral, about how the Armed

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